

Expressive rationalism

Dating from the 1990s, expressive rationalism is neither a consistent architectural style nor a conscious approach. It is more a product of capitalism and mass-consumerism, and developed simultaneously in various parts of the world as the needs of cities changed in the late 20th and early 21st centuries. Although it follows on from modernism in that it furnishes cities, the two differ: expressive rationalism is complex, the buildings are usually used by large numbers (and are thus large in dimensions), and the designs are often achieved through computer modelling and advanced engineering. Herzog & de Meuron's 'Bird's Nest' National Stadium for the 2008 Olympic games in Beijing is an example. With a complex, asymmetrical mesh of steel making up the walls, roof and stairs, it has an inner skin of plastic and a transparent membrane roof. It is also full of Chinese symbolism. On its artificial island in Dubai, Burj al Arab (opposite, 1994–9) is a hotel designed by British architect Tom Wright (b.1957) to resemble a giant yacht's sail and to symbolize luxury, wealth and power.

